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1 Timothy

1 Timothy 1:1–11

Paul had authority because God had commanded him to be an apostle. Using this authority, Paul commanded Timothy to stay in Ephesus and keep working there.

Part of Timothy's work was to command people to stop teaching things that weren't true. The purpose of the commands was love. Paul gave Timothy his command because he loved Timothy and the church in Ephesus. Timothy would show his love for the church in Ephesus by correcting the false teachings.

When people believe true teaching about Jesus, God's love grows strong among them. Some believers in Ephesus taught religious stories and ideas that weren't about Jesus. They also taught about Jewish laws without understanding them.

Paul explained that the Law of Moses showed people what not to do. But the law couldn't make people do what they should do. God makes people able to do what they should do. The Holy Spirit works in the hearts of those who have faith in God. He helps them to know what is honest, right and true.

1 Timothy 1:12–20

Paul used himself as an example of how God works in a person's life. Years before, Paul had opposed the good news about Jesus in violent and evil ways. God had mercy on him.

Paul recognised that he was a sinner and needed the Lord Jesus to save him. Jesus' grace and love completely changed him. Then God trusted Paul with the work of telling others about Jesus. This story about Paul is told in Acts chapter 9.

As Paul wrote about this to Timothy, he was full of thanks. He praised God for his patience and mercy. Paul's example showed that people who speak against Jesus can change. They can be filled with faith and do God's work.

Paul mentioned two believers who spoke evil things against God. Paul said he had handed them over to Satan. Satan is another name for the devil. Paul also wrote about handing people over to Satan in 1 Corinthians 5:1–13. It meant that for a while they couldn't be part of the church community. If they wanted to return they had to turn away from their sin and repent. They had to accept the truth about God.

1 Timothy 2:1–7

Paul made it clear that God wants to save everyone. So Timothy and the believers should pray for all people.

They should also pray for all rulers everywhere. Rulers can bring peace and order to their countries. This is helpful for believers as they follow Jesus and spread the good news.

Preaching the truth about Jesus was Paul's goal. Jesus is both a human being and God at the same time. Jesus brings God and human beings back together. That is what it means for Jesus to be the go-between.

The truth about God is different from what people in Ephesus believed in Paul's time. Most people in Ephesus worshipped the goddess Artemis and also worshipped the Roman ruler Caesar. But Paul said there is only one God. No ruler on earth is God and no one but God can save people.

1 Timothy 2:8–15

Jewish women usually didn't speak during services in synagogues.

It was different in the worship services of believers. In the community of Jesus' followers, both men and women spoke and prophesied. Both men and women served as deacons.

Yet in the city of Ephesus women who weren't believers led the worship of Artemis. Artemis was a false god. This concerned Paul. So he instructed Timothy about how men and women in Ephesus should act during worship services.

Prayer is a holy practice. It wasn't to be used as a way for people to argue with each other. People's bodies are also holy. Clothing wasn't to be used to show off. The good works that people did as they followed Jesus should be what others noticed.

Paul encouraged all people to study and learn. This would help them to not be tricked by lies about God. God is the only Saviour and the only one worthy of worship. People are saved by believing in Jesus and following him.

1 Timothy 3:1–16

Paul described different kinds of church leaders in Ephesus. Some did the work of deacons. All leaders were to set an example about how to think, speak and act.

Paul listed ten things that they must do and five things that they mustn't do. This is like the list Paul wrote about church leaders in Titus 1:1–9. Their minds

must be centred on the truth about who Jesus is. Their words must be honest and true and helpful to others. Their actions must be respected by believers and unbelievers.

They must be faithful in marriage if they are married. They must be wise parents if they have children. They must be constantly growing stronger in their faith. They must be honest about money and not cheat people. They must control themselves. They mustn't drink too much alcohol. They must manage the things they own well. They must be gentle and humble as they serve and lead people.

Paul explained to Timothy why he wrote these instructions about church leaders. He wanted believers to know how they should act. Leaders should teach this by the way they live. The church is God's family. It shows everyone how God wants human beings to live. The church shows everyone the mystery of Christ. This mystery is that Jesus is the Son of God.

1 Timothy 4:1–16

Paul gave Timothy instructions about how to serve Jesus well as a church leader. Timothy was to teach people to be thankful for everything that God created. They didn't need to avoid marriage or certain foods to be holy.

Timothy was to work hard to grow in his spiritual life. People who play sports train their bodies to be healthy and strong. In the same way, Timothy was to train his spirit to be healthy and strong.

This training comes through listening to teachings about Jesus that are true. It comes through reading God's word. It comes through using the gifts of the Spirit. It comes through not giving up hope about living with God for ever.

Timothy must love others and believe that God is the Saviour of all people. Timothy's example would show other believers how to live as faithful followers of Jesus.

1 Timothy 5:1–6:2

As the church leader, Timothy was to treat other believers like family members. They were fathers, mothers, sisters and brothers in God's family. They all had needs and should help take care of one another.

Paul took special care to talk about widows in the church. Church elders were one kind of leader. They were to be respected for serving the church faithfully. When they sinned, it had to be dealt with fairly. This was because the church must be a faithful witness to everyone about Jesus.

Even when leaders serve Jesus faithfully, people might accuse them of doing wrong. Paul explained a fair system. This system would protect church elders if they were falsely accused. Paul also warned Timothy to be careful about appointing new leaders. Appointing leaders was done by placing hands on people. This set them apart to be leaders who served.

Church leaders must be completely committed to turning away from sin. Paul reminded Timothy that no sins stay hidden for ever. Sooner or later people face judgement for their sins. Good works that people do will also be seen and recognised by others.

This was true even in how slaves and slave owners treated one another. Slaves who followed Jesus were to serve their masters with respect. Slave owners were to take good care of those who served them.

1 Timothy 6:3–21

Some believers in Ephesus liked to cause trouble by disagreeing and arguing. Others thought that following Jesus was a way to get rich. Loving money and trying to get more of it led them to do evil things.

Paul told Timothy not to be like those people. Instead, he should be firm in teaching the truth about Jesus as Lord and King. Paul made it very clear that following Jesus doesn't lead people to grow rich. Faithful believers learn to be thankful for what they have and to be happy with it.

Timothy was to warn rich believers not to trust in their money. Instead they were to share freely and put their hope in God. Paul explained that following Jesus brings something much better than riches on earth. When Jesus returns his faithful followers will live with him for ever. That is what Paul called the life that really is life.